



THE NORDIC NATIONS ARE BRANCHES OF A TREE

SCANDINAVIAN COOPERATION (1872)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Legislative harmonization

BEFORE

11th–13th century Regional laws begin to be codified across Scandinavia—for example, the Gulathing's law in Norway (11th century) and the law of Jutland (1241) in Denmark.

AFTER

1880 The first joint Nordic law on bills of exchange is issued.

1901 The Nordic Civil Law Commission is established.

1940s Legislative cooperation among Nordic nations extends to include criminal law.

1952 The Nordic Council is established to encourage cooperation between the parliaments of member nations.

1962 The Helsinki Treaty of cooperation between Nordic nations is signed.

1995 Finland and Sweden join the European Union.

The Scandinavian or Nordic countries of Sweden, Denmark, and Norway have fostered cooperation in the forming of their laws since the end of the 19th century, with Finland and Iceland joining later. This legislative harmony has been one of the most successful aspects of Nordic cooperation, serving as a prime example of the benefits of comparative law and continuing to produce a number of adopted statutes each year.

Scandinavian solidarity

Historically, there has always been close interplay between the Nordic nations. Between 1524 and 1814, Denmark and Norway were joined in a union and, following the efforts of King Christian V, enjoyed a very similar legal code. Likewise, Sweden and Finland were united as one country until war with Russia severed them in 1809. By then, however, a feeling of kinship existed among the Scandinavian nations, and it was believed that unity should be encouraged.

This pro-Scandinavia feeling was channeled toward creating greater uniformity in Nordic law, as this would not only be of practical



King Christian V of Denmark and Norway created a similar legal code for each of the two nations—Danish Law (1683) and Norwegian Law (1687)—based on their existing laws.

use, but would also recognize the region's historical and cultural ties. In 1872, the Scandinavian nations entered into an agreement whereby representative lawyers from each country would meet frequently in order to find common ground on legislation and the administration of justice. Groups of lawyers or representatives from law schools